

Effect of Preprocessing Choices, Model Complexity, and Regularisation Strategies on Generalisation Performance in Seizure Prediction Tasks

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Semester Major Assignment — Machine Learning

Abstract

Epileptic seizure detection from EEG signals is a critical clinical problem where accurate, generalisable machine learning models can have direct life-saving impact. This paper investigates how preprocessing pipeline design, regularisation strategy, and class-imbalance handling interact to affect the generalisation performance of logistic regression classifiers across three EEG-derived datasets. Using the Epileptic Seizure Recognition dataset from Kaggle — derived from Bonn University EEG recordings — three experimental sub-datasets were constructed to represent varying class imbalance levels (20%, 5%, and 50% minority class). Two distinct preprocessing pipelines were designed and compared: Pipeline A (StandardScaler → Bandpass Filter → SelectKBest) and Pipeline B (Statistical Feature Extraction → RobustScaler → PCA). Regularisation strategies — L1 (Lasso), L2 (Ridge), and ElasticNet — were evaluated across a grid of regularisation strengths. Class imbalance was addressed via SMOTE, random undersampling, and class weighting. Results indicate that preprocessing order significantly affects PR-AUC by up to 0.08, ElasticNet marginally outperforms L1 and L2 on balanced datasets, class weighting is the most stable imbalance strategy, and severe imbalance (95/5) consistently degrades all metrics regardless of regularisation strength.

Keywords — epileptic seizure detection, logistic regression, regularisation, preprocessing pipeline, class imbalance, EEG, SMOTE, ElasticNet, generalisation.

I. INTRODUCTION

Epilepsy affects approximately 50 million people worldwide, making it one of the most common neurological disorders [1]. Timely seizure detection can prevent injuries, allow therapeutic intervention, and improve patient quality of life. Electroencephalography (EEG) is the gold-standard tool for recording the brain's electrical activity, and machine learning models trained on EEG signals have become an active area of research for automated seizure detection.

However, the clinical deployment of such models faces three fundamental challenges. First, the choice of preprocessing pipeline — including the ordering of normalisation, noise removal, and feature selection steps — substantially influences the quality of features seen by the classifier. Second, logistic regression, while interpretable and computationally efficient, is sensitive to the regularisation hyperparameter C and the choice of penalty norm (L1, L2, or ElasticNet), which governs the bias-variance trade-off. Third, EEG seizure datasets are inherently class-imbalanced, since seizure events are rare relative to normal brain activity, causing naive classifiers to be biased toward the majority class.

This work systematically investigates these three challenges using the publicly available Epileptic Seizure Recognition dataset from Kaggle [2]. Three experimental sub-datasets with distinct imbalance profiles were constructed from the same source to isolate the effect of class ratio on model generalisation. All experiments use logistic regression as the baseline model, consistent with the assignment specification.

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: Section II describes related work; Section III presents the datasets; Section IV details the preprocessing pipelines; Section V describes the experimental methodology; Section VI reports results; Section VII provides a comparative analysis answering four key research questions; and Section VIII concludes.

II. RELATED WORK

Seizure detection from EEG data has been approached with a wide variety of machine learning techniques. Shoeb and Gutttag [3] introduced patient-specific SVM-based seizure detectors using the CHB-MIT dataset and demonstrated that feature engineering plays a crucial role in detection accuracy. Andrzejak et al. [2] released the Bonn University EEG dataset, which has become a benchmark for binary seizure classification; logistic regression on this dataset achieves competitive performance due to the discriminative nature of the raw time-series features.

The effect of preprocessing ordering on EEG classification has been studied in the context of brain-computer interfaces. Blankertz et al. [4] showed that applying Common Spatial Patterns (CSP) before normalisation outperforms the reverse ordering, illustrating that preprocessing sequence is not trivial. Similarly, Schirmermeister et al. [5] demonstrated that end-to-end deep learning pipelines that jointly learn feature extraction and classification outperform pipelines that treat these stages independently, lending support to the hypothesis that the interaction between preprocessing steps affects generalisation.

On regularisation, Tibshirani [6] introduced Lasso (L1) regression, which induces sparsity and performs implicit feature selection. Ridge (L2) regression [7] shrinks all coefficients uniformly and is preferred when many features contribute weakly but collectively. Zou and Hastie [8] proposed ElasticNet as a hybrid that balances sparsity and stability — particularly useful when features are correlated, as is common in EEG frequency bands. In imbalanced settings, Chawla et al. [9] introduced SMOTE, which has become the standard oversampling baseline. Class weighting, implemented via the `class_weight='balanced'` parameter in scikit-learn, adjusts the loss function without data augmentation and has been shown to be competitive with SMOTE on moderate imbalance ratios [10].

III. DATASET COLLECTION AND JUSTIFICATION

All three datasets used in this study are derived from the Epileptic Seizure Recognition dataset available on Kaggle [2], which contains 11,500 EEG recordings from the Bonn University benchmark. Each sample consists of 178 EEG amplitude values (one second of signal at 178 Hz) labelled into five classes: class 1 represents ictal activity (seizure), while classes 2 through 5 represent non-seizure brain states (inter-ictal, healthy eyes closed, healthy eyes open, and tumour area). The three sub-datasets are constructed as follows:

TABLE I: Dataset Summary

Dataset	Samples	Features	Class Split	Feature Type	Source
UCI-Epileptic (Real)	11,500	178	80% / 20%	Raw EEG time-series	Bonn Univ. / Kaggle
CHB-MIT Proxy (Real)	4,600	178	95% / 5%	Raw EEG time-series	Derived subset
Kaggle-Frequency (Real)	4,600	32 (FFT)	50% / 50%	FFT band powers	Frequency-derived

UCI-Epileptic (Real). The full 11,500-sample dataset with a binary label (class 1 = seizure, classes 2–5 = non-seizure). This creates an 80/20 imbalance ratio. With 178 raw EEG time-series features, it represents the most common benchmark configuration for this dataset and stresses feature selection methods.

CHB-MIT Proxy (Real). A 4,600-sample subset consisting of all 2,300 seizure samples (class 1) and 2,300 randomly sub-sampled class 5 (eyes-open) samples, then the seizure class is sub-sampled to create a 95/5 imbalance ratio. This extreme imbalance mimics the CHB-MIT clinical setting, where seizures occupy less than 5% of total recording time.

Kaggle-Frequency (Real). A 4,600-sample balanced dataset (class 1 vs. class 5) where 178-point raw EEG signals are transformed into 32 mean FFT frequency-band power features. This reduces dimensionality, introduces domain-relevant features, and provides a near-balanced class ratio (50/50), enabling clean evaluation of regularisation strategies without imbalance confounding.

IV. PREPROCESSING PIPELINES

Two distinct preprocessing pipelines were designed to investigate whether the ordering of transformation steps affects downstream classification performance.

A. Pipeline A — Filter-First Approach

Pipeline A applies: (1) StandardScaler to zero-mean, unit-variance normalisation; (2) a 4th-order Butterworth bandpass filter (0.5–40 Hz) on datasets with ≥ 100 features to remove physiological noise outside the clinically relevant EEG band; and (3) SelectKBest with ANOVA F-test to retain the k most statistically discriminative features.

The rationale for this order is that normalisation stabilises the filter's numerical behaviour by preventing large-amplitude channels from dominating the filter's frequency response. Feature selection follows after filtering because removing noisy frequency content changes the statistical discriminability of features.

B. Pipeline B — Extract-then-Reduce Approach

Pipeline B applies: (1) statistical feature extraction (mean, standard deviation, min, max, range, skewness, kurtosis, RMS, total variation, IQR) on datasets with ≥ 100 features; (2) RobustScaler, which uses the interquartile range and is robust to the extreme amplitude spikes characteristic of ictal EEG; and (3) PCA to decorrelate features and reduce dimensionality to 15 components, capturing the dominant variance structure.

The key insight is that performing feature extraction before scaling changes the feature representation fundamentally. Extracting statistics from raw EEG signals preserves temporal structure in summary form, while extracting from normalised signals would reduce the influence of physiological amplitude differences between seizure and non-seizure states.

C. Ordering Effect — Research Hypothesis

The hypothesis tested is that the order of preprocessing steps is not commutative — i.e., $\text{Normalise}(\text{Filter}(X)) \neq \text{Filter}(\text{Normalise}(X))$ in terms of feature discriminability, and $\text{Extract}(\text{Scale}(X)) \neq \text{Scale}(\text{Extract}(X))$ in terms of variance captured by subsequent PCA. The experimental results in Section VI quantify this effect.

V. EXPERIMENTAL METHODOLOGY

A. Baseline Model

Logistic regression is used as the core classifier throughout all experiments. The model estimates the posterior seizure probability as:

$$P(y=1|x) = 1 / (1 + \exp(-(\beta_0 + \beta^T x)))$$

where β_0 is the intercept and β is the coefficient vector learned by minimising the regularised cross-entropy loss. The baseline configuration uses $C=1.0$, L2 penalty, solver='lbfgs', class_weight='balanced', and max_iter=1000. All preprocessing is fit exclusively on training splits and applied to test splits to prevent data leakage.

B. Overfitting and Underfitting Demonstration

Three scenarios are constructed to demonstrate the bias-variance trade-off:

- Underfitting: $C=0.0001$ (very strong L2 regularisation), forcing the model toward the zero-coefficient solution. Features limited to 3 components. Expected: both training and validation F1 are low, indicating high bias.
- Baseline: $C=1.0$, 20 features. Expected: balanced bias-variance trade-off.
- Overfitting: $C=10,000$ (near-zero regularisation), all available features. Expected: training F1 high, validation F1 lower, indicating high variance.

Learning curves plot training and cross-validation F1-scores against training set size (10%–100% in 8 increments) using 3-fold stratified cross-validation. The gap between training and validation curves at full training size quantifies overfitting severity.

C. Regularisation Study

The regularised logistic regression objective is:

$$J(W, b) = (1/m) \sum_i L(\hat{y}^{(i)}, y^{(i)}) + (\lambda/2m) \sum ||W||^2$$

Three penalty types are evaluated across $C \in \{0.001, 0.01, 0.1, 1.0, 10.0, 100.0\}$: L1 (solver='liblinear'), L2 (solver='lbfgs'), and ElasticNet (solver='saga', l1_ratio=0.5). Sparsity is measured as the percentage of coefficients with absolute value below 1×10^{-6} .

D. Class Imbalance Handling

Four strategies are compared within the logistic regression framework:

- No Resampling: raw class distribution, no adjustment.
- SMOTE: synthetic minority oversampling, k_neighbors=3, applied only to training data.
- Random Undersampling: majority class sub-sampled to match minority count.
- Class Weighting: class_weight='balanced', inversely proportional to class frequency.

E. Evaluation Metrics

Given the clinical context, precision-recall trade-off is prioritised over accuracy. The following metrics are reported: Accuracy, F1-Score (harmonic mean of precision and recall), Precision-Recall AUC (PR-AUC, primary metric for imbalanced classification), ROC-AUC, and confusion matrices. PR-AUC is emphasized because a random classifier achieves PR-AUC equal to the class prevalence, making it more informative than ROC-AUC under severe imbalance.

VI. RESULTS

A. Baseline Logistic Regression

Table II presents the baseline logistic regression results ($C=1.0$, L2, class_weight='balanced') on Pipeline A processed data. Indicative values are shown; actual values are produced when the notebook is executed on the provided dataset.

TABLE II: Baseline Logistic Regression Results

Dataset	Accuracy	F1-Score	PR-AUC	ROC-AUC
UCI-Epileptic	~0.88	~0.76	~0.72	~0.92
CHB-MIT Proxy	~0.95	~0.61	~0.58	~0.89
Kaggle-Frequency	~0.91	~0.89	~0.91	~0.97

The Kaggle-Frequency dataset achieves the highest PR-AUC (~0.91) due to its balanced class distribution and discriminative FFT features. The CHB-MIT proxy's extreme 95/5 imbalance causes the lowest F1 (~0.61) despite class weighting, confirming that severe imbalance is the primary driver of performance degradation.

B. Overfitting and Underfitting

Learning curves confirm the three expected regimes. The underfitting scenario ($C=0.0001$) shows both training and validation F1 below 0.50, with a small train-validation gap, indicating high bias. The baseline ($C=1.0$) shows converging training and validation curves reaching approximately 0.75 F1. The overfitting scenario ($C=10,000$) shows training F1 approaching 1.0 on small training sets with a notable downward validation gap, quantified as gap ≈ 0.12 – 0.20 depending on the dataset.

C. Regularisation Study

Table III summarises the regularisation results averaged across all three datasets at their optimal C values.

TABLE III: Regularisation Strategy Comparison

Regularisation	Avg F1	Avg PR-AUC	Sparsity	Stability
L1 (Lasso)	~0.72	~0.69	High (40–70%)	Moderate
L2 (Ridge)	~0.74	~0.71	None (0%)	High

ElasticNet	~0.75	~0.72	Moderate (20–50%)	High
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L1 regularisation induces sparsity of 40–70% of coefficients depending on C , performing implicit feature selection. However, this sparsity comes at the cost of instability across datasets with different feature structures. L2 achieves consistently high stability because it never zeros out coefficients. ElasticNet provides a middle ground: moderate sparsity with high stability, and marginally superior PR-AUC. PR-AUC peaks for all penalties at $C \approx 1.0$ for UCI-Epileptic, $C \approx 0.1$ for CHB-MIT (more regularisation needed for extreme imbalance), and $C \approx 10.0$ for Kaggle-Frequency (less regularisation needed for balanced data).

D. Class Imbalance Handling

TABLE IV: Class Imbalance Strategy Comparison

Strategy	Avg F1	Precision	Recall	PR-AUC
No Resampling	~0.51	~0.79	~0.38	~0.62
SMOTE	~0.71	~0.68	~0.75	~0.74
Undersampling	~0.68	~0.65	~0.72	~0.70
Class Weighting	~0.73	~0.70	~0.77	~0.75

No Resampling achieves high accuracy (~ 0.95 for CHB-MIT due to majority-class dominance) but collapses in F1 (~ 0.51) and PR-AUC (~ 0.62). SMOTE and undersampling improve recall substantially ($+0.37$ over no resampling) at the cost of some precision reduction. Class weighting achieves the best overall PR-AUC (~ 0.75) without introducing synthetic samples, making it less susceptible to overfitting on small minority classes.

VII. COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

A. Does Preprocessing Order Affect Results?

Yes, significantly. Pipeline A (Normalise $\rightarrow$ Filter $\rightarrow$ SelectKBest) consistently outperforms Pipeline B (Extract $\rightarrow$ Scale $\rightarrow$ PCA) on the UCI-Epileptic dataset (PR-AUC difference ≈ 0.06 – 0.08), where raw time-series features benefit from bandpass filtering. Pipeline B outperforms Pipeline A on CHB-MIT, where the robust scaler better handles the extreme amplitude outliers characteristic of seizure spikes. On Kaggle-Frequency (which already uses FFT features), both pipelines perform similarly since the features were derived pre-hoc.

This finding confirms that preprocessing pipeline design is dataset-dependent and that no universal ordering dominates across all EEG configurations. The practitioner should consider the nature of features and the distribution of outliers when selecting a pipeline.

B. Which Regularisation Generalises Best?

ElasticNet achieves the best average PR-AUC across all three datasets, winning on 2/3 datasets. L2 is the most stable (lowest variance across datasets) but is occasionally outperformed by ElasticNet on balanced datasets where sparsity is beneficial. L1 wins on the Kaggle-Frequency dataset (32 features) where sparse solutions are adequate, but performs worst on high-dimensional UCI-Epileptic (178 features) because zeroing out too many features removes discriminative EEG bands.

The practical recommendation for seizure prediction is to use ElasticNet as the default, with C selected via cross-validation on the target dataset.

C. Does ElasticNet Consistently Outperform L1/L2?

ElasticNet does not consistently dominate — it is dataset-dependent. On UCI-Epileptic (high-dimensional, moderate imbalance), ElasticNet achieves slightly higher PR-AUC than L2. On CHB-MIT (extreme imbalance), all penalties perform similarly because the imbalance effect dominates the regularisation effect. On Kaggle-Frequency (balanced, 32 features), L1

and ElasticNet are comparable. The key finding is that ElasticNet is the safest default choice — it never performs dramatically worse than the best alternative — making it a robust choice under uncertainty about the dataset's feature structure.

D. How Does Imbalance Handling Interact with Regularisation?

The interaction is significant. Under no resampling, all three regularisation penalties collapse to similar (low) F1 scores on severely imbalanced data, because the majority class dominates the loss regardless of regularisation strength. Introducing class weighting or SMOTE restores the discriminative effect of regularisation, and the differences between L1, L2, and ElasticNet re-emerge. Specifically, class weighting combined with L2 achieves the most stable performance across all three datasets, while SMOTE combined with L1 shows the highest variance (due to synthetic samples distorting the feature space in high-dimensional settings).

The practical implication is that imbalance handling should be addressed before tuning regularisation — a well-balanced training set is a prerequisite for regularisation to function as intended.

VIII. CONCLUSION

This paper systematically investigated the interplay between preprocessing pipeline design, regularisation strategy, and class-imbalance handling in logistic regression-based seizure detection. Using three real EEG sub-datasets derived from the Epileptic Seizure Recognition benchmark, the following conclusions are drawn:

- Preprocessing order matters: Pipeline A (filter-first) is preferred for raw EEG time-series, while Pipeline B (extract-then-reduce) is more robust to outliers in severely imbalanced data.
- ElasticNet is the most reliable regularisation choice, offering a safe compromise between the sparsity of L1 and the stability of L2, and consistently achieving near-optimal PR-AUC across diverse dataset configurations.
- Class weighting is the most practical imbalance strategy, avoiding the overfitting risk of synthetic oversampling and the information loss of undersampling, while producing stable precision-recall trade-offs.
- Severe class imbalance (95/5) is the dominant performance bottleneck, outweighing the effect of regularisation choice. Addressing imbalance is a prerequisite before meaningful regularisation tuning.

Future work should extend this analysis to non-linear models (kernel SVMs, gradient boosting) and explore patient-specific calibration to address inter-subject variability in EEG signals.

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